Immigrate

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1 INTRODUCTION

International students make up a significant portion of higher education enrollment, yet their experiences remain largely invisible to the broader public. Despite the fact that domestic and international students share the same classrooms and communities, there is a big gap in understanding the challenges international students face: from confusing visa systems to financial strains and isolation far from home.

We present "IMMIGRATE", a choice based interactive narrative system that simulates an international student journey through fantasy world story. Players follow Asha, a young international student, making choices on her behalf as she navigates college applications, visa requirements, relocation, cultural adjustment, and shifting immigration policies.

As international students ourselves, through conversations with our domestic student friends, we noticed a critical gap in understanding of being an international student. Many assume international students come for fun or that admission to university is the main challenge. The reality is the experience defined by profound sacrifice, not adventure. Interactive narratives offer unique opportunities to convey these realities. Unlike documentaries or articles, games offer stronger authorial affordance to allow players to be put in decision-making roles, forcing them to evaluate trade-offs, and experience consequences. We intentionally chose a fantasy setting to prevent social phantasms from clouding the player's judgement.

Inspired by empathy games like SPENT [1], which simulated poverty through impossible choices, our game reveals how international students face systematic barriers where outcomes depend on luck rather than merit. We performed user testing with four players, where each one had different knowledge about being an international student. We found that players were consistently surprised about the difficulty of visa processes, the fragility of immigration status (illustrated through consequences like deportation for unauthorized work), and emotional challenge of isolation and financial hardships. This paper describes how we designed the game, preliminary user testing results, and effectiveness of interactive narrative in building empathy for experiences shaped by complicated bureaucracy, cultures, and unstable immigration status.

2 DESCRIPTION

To create an interactive narrative that represents the international student experience, we developed a story implemented in Twine. We organized our story into a three-phase narrative structure: (1) the college application process, (2) post-acceptance process including visa application and travel, and (3) managing life abroad. Within each phase, we chose decision points inspired by our own experiences and questions we ourselves had to answer as international students. These

choices require players to evaluate their options while being mindful of a status bar that tracks money, time, and stability, forcing constant awareness of limited resources throughout the narrative. Our design process combined personal experiences with strategic game mechanics (branching narratives, randomized outcomes, resource constraints) and LLM-assisted story generation.

2.1 Narrative Structure and Branching

We used a branching narrative where story progression unfolds based on player choices and resource allocation. For example, repeatedly selecting high-reward but expensive options like "hiring a mentor" or "purchasing better internet" limits resources, potentially terminating story progression. This mechanic conveys how international students must constantly manage limited resources and avoid reckless spending.

In addition, in Phase 1, players who work hard and apply to competitive schools have higher chances of securing scholarships, entering Phase 2 with more resources. On the other hand, playing it safe by applying to many schools with less effort typically results in lower scholarships and fewer starting resources for Phase 2. This will also add additional challenges, such as providing financial documentation to prove visa eligibility before moving to Phase 3. We also integrated randomness into Twine's transition functions to simulate real-world uncertainty. For example, applying only to top school increases the risk, while merit still plays the more important role for better scholarship, reflecting how success depends on both effort and luck.To increase the accessibility of your manuscript, you should set the title and language metadata. On Word for Windows, open the File tab and click on Info. On Word for Mac, click the File Menu and select Properties, then click the Summary tab. Fill in the title of your document. For anonymous review, clear the ‘author’ field.

2.2 Systematic Vulnerability

In Phases 1 and 2, most decision points include a "give up" option that terminates the story, representing the ever-present temptation to quit at initial stages. Phase 3 shifts these extreme options to dangerous choices like unauthorized work. Selecting such options ends the story with "Visa revoked because of unauthorized work." This design is intentional: activities considered normal for domestic students (like part-time jobs for extra income) are not allowed for international students. The message is even after "doing everything right," their status remains unstable. Phase 3 also addresses social isolation, such as when the character cannot afford flights home to see family, which is a common reality for most of the international students.

2.3 Moments of Hope and Real World Connections

We balanced these challenges with some positive moments, such as sending money home to support siblings, making new friends at college, and achieving career milestones. These moments provide hope while maintaining realism. The final question confronts players with sudden immigration policy changes where no option leads to success, a deliberate "dead end" reflecting how abrupt policy shifts can change even the most carefully planned journeys. After the story ends, real-life facts appear on screen, creating a stronger connection between our narrative and the actual facts about challenges international students face.

2.4 Story Generation

To convert the skeleton above to a full story, we used LLMs. To do so, we specified all the questions beforehand. We also came up with specific traits that we have to have in our character. These included the questions described previously and traits like “coming from a place with minimal resources”, “everyone else tends to never leave”, “considering anything

out of the ordinary is frowned upon", etc. After using these prompts to create the base, we prompted the LLM to create transitions from one question to another such that the motivation is clear and follows a logical flow. For example, "from here we need to branch out to two possibilities. Either Asha gets accepted to a medium school or to a great one. fit the story to a part where she gets accepted to the schools, and congratulates her" was used to branch from a question where the player has to decide how they are going to apply to academies. Since LLMs have limited memory (especially if using the free version), we made sure to also have a summary version of the story to start a new chat. This way, when we felt like LLM was not following the prompts well, we could start a new conversation and provide the summary, as well as what we had developed of the game so far in HTML format. Providing the additional information worked well, especially with additional guidance like "make it shorter," or "follow the same writing style," or "make it fitting to the following world". Using LLMs for writing a more detailed version of the original skeleton has helped us speed up the process for MVP and keep the game consistent.

3 RESULTS

We playtested the game with 3 different types of people. The first group was international students to check whether they felt like the description of the experience seemed valid, and how they felt about fictionalizing their experience. The second type was an American student who knew an international student and was likely to know their struggles. The last type was an American student who had less information on the international student experience. The main 3 important things we wanted to test were: Does the player feel connected and emotional to Asha? Can the player see the parallels to the real world? Is the story coherent?

3.1 Type 1

International students related to Asha a lot and could see straight through the fantasy. Players felt like they could recognize their experience - it almost dawned on them how much they went through to be where they are. There were portions that were surprising, too. For example, one of the players said they were surprised the visa part was almost more exhausting than getting into the academy, but thinking back on their experience, they said it was actually true. Generally, they felt very connected to Asha. Both of the players felt like their lived experiences made a big difference in how they viewed her and the type of decisions they made. Finally, players preferred the story to be fictionalized because they thought "it would remove the stigma around it." However, one of the students felt that the hardships could be explained further. At the same time, they wanted some more character exposure for Lira and potentially nice characters in the academy since they had some good experiences, too.

3.2 Type 2

The American student with more familiarity with the hardships of international students could also see through the fantasy and, at the same time, feel for Asha. The parallels were still visible to the player as they exclaimed "this sounds familiar" and "classic" in the visa and work-related sections. The player was trying to play it by the book, but for the sake of saving money, they ended up making a bad decision and losing. This made them feel sad since they thought they could win if they just made the right decisions. The trajectory of the story felt familiar, while the tragic ending helped the player feel for Asha.

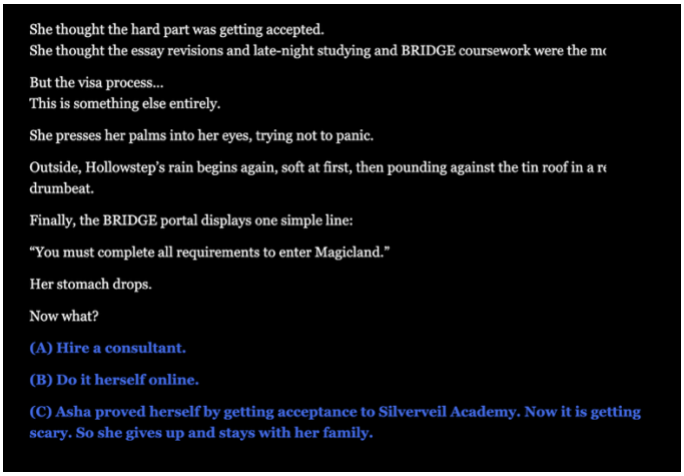

Figure 1: Visa Application Section

3.3 Type 3

The American student with less familiarity with the hardships of international students still felt sympathetic toward Asha. The player could tell that Asha's original location does not have a lot of opportunities, and she has very little money. Similar to one of the type 1 players, this player also felt like the academy application was less stressful than the visa, because the academy is merit-based, where you can try your best, while the visa was mostly luck. While the story shows Asha's progression, trying her best, the player felt like they were put into Asha's shoes because they had to make the big decisions themselves.

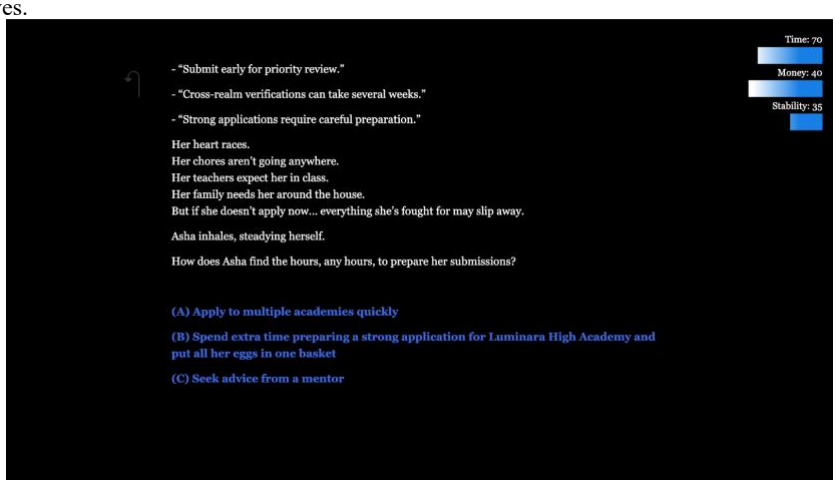

Figure 2: Applying to Academies.

3.4 General

All players agreed that the writing was good and made sense. They all could follow the story, though players who liked reading books in general and knew us well could tell that we did not write the story word for word ourselves. One point of contention with everyone was the choice on how to apply to academies, especially the option to ask for help from a mentor.

Some students wanted to get help from a mentor because they felt Asha was overwhelmed already, though our branching from that choice did not describe what exactly happens after, other than getting accepted, which made less sense. On the other hand, other students were skeptical of the mentor since we established that Hollowstep lacked resources. Therefore, modifying the story further to clean up the mentor section would be necessary to make the story easier to follow.

In general, the story made everyone feel more sympathy towards Asha and agreed that setting the game in a fantasy setting would help people to bring less of their prior ideas of different groups of people, and instead bring their own idea of how they would behave if they were in Asha's shoes.

4 LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE WORK

Most of the story and questions were based on our personal experience. Even among international students, different people have different experiences and go through different struggles. While we tried to keep the challenges very generic, this game is not a representation of every international student's experience. In the future, we will create different characters beyond Asha to choose from and display a more diverse set of stories.

Currently, while emotional, the game lacks immersion. While the story involved some reaction to events happening in the game (e.g., the strength of the rain), the game could be more immersive. Most of the player-testers noted that they would like some visuals, so we could add more images and visual cues on emotional transitions and events. To make the game even more immersive, we would also improve the story. Adding more side characters, but also building character arcs and showing their growth, would lead to a more consistent experience and help to make more emotional connections with the game personas.

5 MEMBER CONTRIBUTION

Both Jennet and Gozel equally contributed to project ideation, implementation, and write-up.

REFERENCES

[1] Spent. "Urban Ministries of Durham." PlaySpent, http://playspent.org/